2 CHRONICLES

Conversational Yahveh Covenant

Solomon Asks for Wisdom

1:1Solomon secured himself in his kingdom; Yahveh God was with him and made him great. 2He called together all Israel—the commanders of thousands and hundreds, the judges and every leader, the heads of families in Israel. 3He led the whole assembly went to the high place at Gibeon; God's Tent of Meeting was there that Moses had made in the countryside. 4But David had brought the Ark up from Kiriath-jearim to the tent he'd made for it in Jerusalem. 5The bronze altar that Bezalel Ben-Uri Ben-Hur had made, was there in front of the Tabernacle. Solomon and the assembly went to it, 6and he offered 1,000 burnt offerings on it. **2 Ch 1:1-6**

7That night God appeared to him,

"Ask me *what you want me to give you."*

8He said,

"You've dealt with my father David with great enduring love and made me king in his place. 9You've fulfilled your promise to him and made me king over a people as numerous as dust on the ground. 10Give me wisdom and knowledge so I can carry on my work for them. Who can rule such a great people as yours?"

11God said,

"Since that was in your mind and you haven't asked for possessions, wealth, honor, a long life, or your enemies' lives, 12I'll give you wisdom and knowledge; <u>and</u> I'll give you possessions, wealth, and honor like no other *king ever had or will have."*

13He came back to Jerusalem and reigned over Israel. **2 Ch 1:7-13**

14Solomon amassed 1,400 chariots and 12,000 cavalry and stationed them in chariot cities and in Jerusalem. 15He made silver and gold as common as stone in Jerusalem, and cedars as common as sycamores in the western foothills. 16He imported horses from Egypt, and his traders bought them from Kue. 17They brought in chariots from Egypt for 15 lbs 600 shekels of silver apiece and horses for 3¾ lbs 150 shekels of silver each. They also exported them to the kings of the Hittites and Aram. **2 Ch 2:14-17**

Preparations for Building the Temple

2:1Solomon decided to build a temple for Yahveh's name and a royal palace for himself. 2He assigned 70,000 to transport materials, 80,000 to quarry *stone* in the mountains, and 3,600 to supervise them. 3He sent word to Hiram, king of Tyre,

"As you sent my father David cedars for his palace, do for me. **4***I'm getting ready to build a temple for Yahveh my God and dedicate it to him for burning fragrant incense and offering burnt offerings morning and evening on Sabbaths, new moons, and Yahveh's appointed festivals—items of worship required permanently in Israel.* **5***The temple I'm going to build will be great, because our God is greater than all* other *gods.* **6***But who can build him a temple? The sky, the highest heavens, can't contain him; who am I to build him a temple, except for burning incense to him?* **7***Send me a man skilled at working in gold, silver, brass, and iron; in purple, crimson, and violet fabrics; a man that knows how to engrave and work with the skilled men I have in Judah and Jerusalem that my father provided.* **8***Send me cedar, cypress, and algum wood from Lebanon; your woodsmen know how to cut timber in Lebanon. My men will work with yours* **9***to prepare an abundance of it for the great, wonderful temple I'm going to build.* **10***I'll give your woodsmen that cut the logs 220,000 bushels [20,000 kors] of crushed wheat, 220,000 bushels [20,000 kors] of barley, 180,000 gallons [20,000 baths] of wine, and 180,000 gallons [20,000 baths] of oil."* **2 Ch 2:1-10**

11Hiram wrote back,

"Since Yahveh loves his people, he's made you their king. **12***Bless Yahveh God of Israel that made earth and sky and gave King David a wise son endowed with discretion and understanding, who will build a temple for Yahveh and a royal palace for himself.* **13***I'm sending Huram-abi, an intelligent master craftsman,* **14***the son of a woman from Dan and a father from Tyre. He knows how to work in gold, silver, bronze, iron, wood, and stone, as well as in purple, violet, linen, and crimson fabrics. He knows how to do all kinds of engravings and carry out any design you assign him. He can work with your skilled men and those of my lord David.* **15** *Send us the wheat and barley, oil and wine you've offered.* **16***We'll cut whatever timber you need and bring it to you on rafts by sea to Joppa so you can transport it up to Jerusalem."*

17Solomon counted the foreigners in Israel according to David's census and found there were 153,600 of them. **18**He appointed 80,000 to quarry *stones* in the mountains, 70,000 to transport materials, and 3,600 to supervise the workers. **2 Ch 2:11-18**

Solomon Builds the Temple

3:**1**Solomon started building Yahveh's Temple on Mount Moriah, where *Yahveh* had appeared to David, the place David prepared on the threshing floor of Ornan/*Araunah* the Jebusite. **2He began construction on the second day, second month, fourth year of his reign**.

3The foundation for God's Temple was 30 x 90ft.

4The porch in front of it was 30ft wide and 180ft tall, overlaid with pure gold inside.

5He lined the Temple itself with cypress wood overlaid with fine gold and decorated with palm trees and chains;

6adorned the Temple with precious stones—the gold was from Parvaim;

7overlaid the Temple with gold—the beams, thresholds, walls, and doors—and carved cherubs on the walls;

8made the Holy of Holies—30ft square, equaling the width of the Temple—and overlaid it with 22 2/3 tons 600 talents of fine gold—**9**the spikes weighed 20 oz 50 shekels of gold;

overlaid the upper rooms with gold. **2 Ch 3:1-9**

10He made 2 sculpted cherubs in the Holy of Holies and overlaid them with gold. **11**The combined wingspan of the cherubs was 30ft. The wing of one (7½ft) touched the wall of the Temple. The other wing (7½ft) touched the wing of the second cherub. **12**The wing of the second cherub (7½ft) touched the *opposite* wall. The other wing (7½ft) was attached to the wing of the first cherub. **13**They stood on their feet facing the nave.

14He made a curtain out of violet, purple, crimson, and fine linen, and worked cherubs on it;

15two pillars in front of the Temple 53ft tall, with 7½ft capitals on top of each one;

16chains in the inner sanctuary and on top of the pillars;

100 pomegranates and put them on the chains;

17He set up the pillars on the right and left that he named *Jachin* and *Boaz* respectively.

2 Ch 3:10-17

Temple Furnishings

4:**1**He made

a bronze altar 30 x 30 x 15ft high;

2a circular, cast-metal sea 15ft from brim to brim, 7½ft deep and 45ft around.

3Figures of gourds were under it, entirely circling the sea (45ft). The oxen were in 2 rows cast in one piece with the Sea. **4**It stood on 12 oxen, 3 facing out in each direction with their hindquarters inward. **5**It was 4ins thick, with a brim like a cup—like a lily blossom. It could hold 27,000 gallons 3,000 baths.

6He made 10 basins to wash in, and set 5 on each side for rinsing things for the burnt offering; but the sea was for the priests to wash in;

710 golden lampstands in the way prescribed, and set them in the Temple, 5 on each side; **2 Ch 4:1-7**

[8]10 tables placed in the Temple, 5 on each side;
100 gold bowls;
[9]the court of priests, the great court, and bronze-plated doors for the court.
[10]He set the sea on the right side of the Temple toward the southeast. **2 Ch 4:8-10**

[11]Huram made the pails, shovels, and bowls, and finished the work for King Solomon on God's Temple: [12]the 2 pillars, the bowls and 2 capitals on top of the pillars, the 2 networks to cover the 2 bowls on the capitals; [13]the 400 pomegranates for the 2 networks, 2 rows for each network to cover the 2 bowls of the capitals, [14]the stands and the basins on the stands, [15]the sea with 12 oxen under it.

[16]*Huram* made the pails, shovels, forks, and utensils out of polished bronze. [17]The king had them cast in the clay soil between Succoth and Zeredah on the Jordan plain. [18]Solomon made these utensils in great numbers. The weight of the bronze couldn't be calculated.

[19]Solomon made everything in God's Temple out of purest gold: the altar, the tables for the Bread of the Presence, [20]the lampstands with their lamps to burn in front of the inner sanctuary as prescribed, [21]the flowers, lamps, tongs; [22]the snuffers, bowls, spoons, firepans; the entrance to the Temple, its inner doors for the Holy of Holies, and the doors of the Temple (the nave). **2 Ch 4:11-22**

5:[1]When Solomon finished the work on Yahveh's Temple, he brought in the silver, gold, and utensils David had dedicated, and put them in the treasuries in God's Temple.

The Ark Brought to the Temple

[2]Then he gathered to Jerusalem the elders in Israel, the heads of tribes and families, in preparation for bringing up the Ark from The City of David (Zion). [3]The men of Israel gathered to him at the festival in the seventh month. [4]The elders came, and the Levites picked up the Ark [5]and brought it up. *They brought up* the Tent of Meeting and the holy utensils that were in it. [6]King Solomon and the community were sacrificing so many sheep and oxen they couldn't keep count of them. [7]The priests brought the Ark to its place in the inner sanctuary, the Holy of Holies, under the cherubs. [8]They spread their wings over it and covered it and its poles. [9]The poles were long enough to be visible in front of the inner sanctuary, but not outside; they're still there. [10]The only things in the Ark were the two tablets Moses put there at Horeb/*Sinai*, where Yahveh made a covenant with the Israelites after they came out of Egypt. **2 Ch 5:1-10**

[11]When the priests came out of the Holy Place, they'd sanctified themselves without regard to divisions. [12]The Levitical singers Asaph, Heman, Jeduthun, and their sons and relatives, dressed in fine linen, with cymbals, harps, and lyres. They stood east of the altar with 120 priests blowing trumpets. [13]The singers made themselves heard to Yahveh's praise and

honor, and sang out accompanied by trumpets, cymbals, and musical instruments. When they praised Yahveh, and said, *"He's good because his love endures forever,"* his Temple filled with such a cloud [14]the priests couldn't carry out their service. Yahveh's glory filled his Temple.

2 Ch 5:11-14

Solomon Praises Yahveh

6[1]Then Solomon said,

"You've[Y] *said you'd be in the dense cloud.*
[2]*I've built you a lofty temple,*
a permanent place for you to live."

[3]Then he faced *the people* and blessed the assembly standing there,

[4]*"Bless Yahveh God of Israel, who said to my father David,* [5]*'From the time I brought my people out of Egypt, I hadn't chosen a city to build a temple in for my name. I hadn't chosen any man as a leader over Israel.* [6]*But I've chosen Jerusalem as the place to identify with and David as* leader *over Israel.* [7]*My father wanted to build him a temple,* [8]*but Yahveh said, 'You meant well,* [9]*but you won't build me a temple; your son will.'* [10]*He has fulfilled that promise; I've risen to the throne and built the temple for his name.* [11]*That's where I've set the Ark that holds the covenant he made with Israel."*

Solomon's Prayer of Dedication

[12-13]Solomon had built a bronze platform 7½ x 7½ x 4½ft high beside the altar in the middle of the court. He stood on it, knelt, and spread out his hands toward heaven. **2 Ch 6:1-13**

[14]*"Yahveh God of Israel, there's no God like you in heaven or on earth. You keep covenant and show enduring love to everyone that follows you with all their heart.* [15]*You've kept your promise to David. You've said it with your mouth and fulfilled it with your hand.* [16]*Keep*[Y] *this promise too, 'You'll always have a descendant on Israel's throne if they follow my Law like you have.'* [17]*Confirm that promise now.*

[18]*"But will you live with people on earth? The sky and highest heaven can't contain you, much less this Temple I've built.* [19]*Yet attend to my petition. Listen to my call* [20]*so you'll be looking toward this Temple day and night where you've said you'd put your name.* [21]*Listen when your people and I pray toward this place. Listen from heaven and forgive.*

[22]*"When someone sins against another and comes here to take an oath at your altar,* [23]*then listen from heaven and judge them. Punish the sinful by*

bringing their way on their own head and justify the good by rewarding them according to their goodness. **2 Ch 6:14-23**

24 *"When an enemy defeats your people because they've sinned, if they repent, confess your name, and petition you in this Temple,* **25***<u>then listen</u> from heaven, forgive them, and bring them back to the country you've given them and their ancestors.*

26 *"When there's no rain because they've sinned against you and they pray toward this place, confess your name, and turn from their sin when you punish them,* **27***<u>then listen</u> from heaven and forgive your people. Teach them the good way to live and send rain on the land you've given them to inherit.* **2 Ch 6:24-27**

28 *"When there's a famine in the country; disease, blight or mildew; locust or grasshopper; a sickness, or an enemy laying siege to our towns—***29***whatever petition your people make, each knowing their own suffering and pain and spreading their hands toward this Temple,* **30***<u>then listen</u> from where you live, forgive, and render to each as they've done—only you know everyone's heart—*
31*so they'll respect you and follow your ways as long as they live in the country you've given their ancestors.*

32 *"When foreigners come from a distant country because of your great name, your powerful hand and outstretched arm, and pray toward this Temple,* **33***<u>then listen</u> from where you live, and do everything they call to you for, so every nation will know you and respect you like your people do, and so they'll know that the Temple I've built wears your name.*

34 *"When your people go out to battle by whatever way you send them and they pray to you toward this city you've chosen and the Temple I've built,* **35***<u>then listen</u> from heaven and support them.* **2 Ch 6:28-35**

36 *"When they sin against you (everybody sins), you're angry with them, and deliver them to an enemy that takes them captive near or far,* **37***if they take it to heart, repent, and petition you, 'We've sinned, we've committed iniquity, we've acted wickedly';* **38***if they come back to you with all their heart and soul, and pray toward the land you've given their ancestors, the city you've chosen, the Temple*
33*<u>then listen</u> from where you live, and do everything they call to you for, so every nation will know you and respect you like your people do, and so they'll know that the Temple I've built wears your name.*

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> [36] *"When they sin against you (everybody sins), you're angry with them, and deliver them to an enemy that takes them captive near or far,* [37] *if they take it to heart, repent, and petition you, 'We've sinned, we've committed iniquity, we've acted wickedly';* [38] *if they come back to you with all their heart and soul, and pray toward the land you've given their ancestors, the city you've chosen, the Temple I've built,* [39] *then listen from where you live, support them, and forgive them.*
>
> [40] *"Open your eyes and ears to answer the prayer I've offered here.* [41] *Rise, Yahveh God, to your resting place, you and your powerful Ark. Cover* your *priests with salvation; may your holy people celebrate what's good.* [42] *Don't turn away from your anointed one. Remember your enduring love for your servant David."*
>
> **2 Ch 6:36-42**

The Dedication of the Temple

7[1]When Solomon finished praying, fire came down from the sky and consumed the burnt offering and sacrifices, and Yahveh's glory filled the Temple. [2]The priests couldn't go in because of it. [3]When the Israelites saw the fire and Yahveh's glory come down on the Temple, they bowed down on the pavement with their faces to the ground in worship and praised him, *"He's truly good; his love endures forever."*

[4]Then the king and the people sacrificed to Yahveh [5]22,000 oxen and 120,000 sheep. That's how he and the people dedicated God's Temple. [6]The priests and Levites stood at their positions with the musical instruments King David had made for praising Yahveh—*"his love endures forever"*—whenever he gave praise by their means, while the priests on the other side blew trumpets, and Israel stood. [7]Solomon consecrated the middle of the court in front of Yahveh's Temple, because that's where he offered the burnt offerings and the fat of the peace offerings, *and* because the bronze altar he'd made couldn't hold the burnt offering, grain offering, and fat. **2 Ch 7:1-7**

[8]Solomon and all Israel observed the festival for a week, a huge assembly from Lebo-hamath to the River of Egypt. [9]They observed the dedication of the altar, kept the festival, and held a solemn assembly on the eighth day. [10]The **twenty-third day, seventh month**, Solomon sent the people home, celebrating and happy over Yahveh's goodness to David, Solomon, and his people.

The LORD's Response to Solomon

[11]Solomon finished Yahveh's Temple, the king's palace, and everything he'd planned to do with them. [12]Then Yahveh appeared to him at night and said,

> *"I've heard your prayer, and I've chosen this place as a temple for sacrificing.* [13] *If I shut up the sky so there's no rain, or command locusts to devour the land, or send a plague among my people,* [14] *and they humble themselves and pray, I'll hear from heaven, forgive their sin, and restore their*

land. **15***My eyes will be open and my ears attentive to prayers offered here.* **16***I've chosen and consecrated this Temple so my name will be here permanently.* **17***If you*^{sg} *conduct yourself like your father and do everything I've commanded you and keep my statutes and ordinances,* **18***I'll make your throne secure like I agreed with David to do, 'You'll always have a descendant on Israel's throne if they follow my law like you have.'*

19*"But if you*^{pl} *leave my statutes and commandments and worship and serve other gods,* **20***I'll uproot you from the country I've given you and throw aside this Temple I've consecrated to myself. I'll make it something mocked, a byword the world over.* **21***Everybody that goes by will be amazed at this Temple that had been so highly praised, 'Why has Yahveh done such a thing to this country and this Temple?'* **22***People will answer, 'They abandoned Yahveh God who brought their ancestors out of Egypt. They adopted other gods, worshiped and served them.'"* **2 Ch 7:8-22**

Solomon's Other Activities

8:1 At the end of the 20 years it took Solomon to build Yahveh's Temple and his own palace, **2**he rebuilt the towns Hiram had given him and settled Israelites in them. **3**Then he captured Hamath-zobah **4**and built Tadmor in the open country and storage cities in Hamath. **5**He built Upper and Lower Beth-horon, fortified towns with walls, gates, and bars. **6**He *built* Baalath, the storage cities he had, towns for his chariots and cavalry, and everything he delighted to build in Jerusalem, Lebanon, and the rest of the territory he ruled.

7The people left over from the Hittites, Amorites, Perizzites, Hivites, and Jebusites, who weren't Israelites **8**the Israelites hadn't destroyed, Solomon has made forced laborers ever since. **9**He didn't make slaves out of Israelites for his work. They were soldiers, chief captains, and commanders of his chariots and cavalry. **10**Solomon had 250 chief officers that oversaw the people. **11**Then he brought Pharaoh's daughter up from The City of David to the house he'd built for her, because he said, *"My wife won't live in David's palace, because the places are holy where Yahveh's Ark has been."* **2 Ch 8:1-11**

12Then Solomon offered burnt offerings on the altar he'd built in front of the vestibule. **13**He followed the daily rule, offering them according to the commandment of Moses for Sabbaths, new moons, and the three annual festivals: The Festival of Unleavened Bread, The Festival of Weeks, and The Festival of Booths.

14He followed David's ordinance and appointed the priestly divisions for their service: the Levites for their duties of praise and serving in the presence of the priests by the daily rule; the gatekeepers by their divisions at every gate. **15**They kept his commandments to the priests and Levites about the treasuries.

16Solomon carried out his work from the day he laid the foundation of Yahveh's Temple till he finished it. **17**Then he went to Ezion-geber and Eloth on the shore in Edom. **18**By his own officers, Hiram sent him ships and sailors that knew the sea. They went with Solomon's servants to Ophir and brought back 17 tons [450 talents] of gold. **2 Ch 8:12-18**

The Queen of Sheba Visits Solomon

9:1 When the queen of Sheba heard about Solomon, she came to Jerusalem to test him with hard questions. She brought a large contingent of camels carrying spices, and lots of gold and precious stones. When she got there, she talked to him about everything on her mind. **2**He answered her questions; there wasn't anything he couldn't explain to her. **3**When she'd seen his wisdom, the palace he'd built, **4**the food at his table, the seating of his officials, the attendance by his servers and their attire, his cupbearers and their attire, the stairway he used to go up to Yahveh's Temple, she was breathless,

> **5***"The report was true that I heard in my country about your words and wisdom.* **6***But I didn't believe it till I saw it. They didn't tell me half of it.* **7***How fortunate your officers must feel, being around you continually and listening to your wisdom.* **8***Bless Yahveh your God that delighted in you and set you on his throne. He loved Israel and established the* nation *permanently; that's why he made you their king—to do justice and goodness."* **2 Ch 9:1-8**

9She gave him 4½ tons [120 talents] of gold and a large amount of spices and precious stones. There'd never been spices like what she gave him. **10**Then Hiram and Solomon's crews brought gold from Ophir plus algum wood and precious stones. **11**From the algum *wood* he made steps for Yahveh's Temple and the king's palace as well as lyres and harps for the singers. Nobody in Judah had ever seen anything like them. **12**King Solomon gave the queen of Sheba everything she asked for—more than what she'd brought him. Then she and her attendants went back to her country. **2 Ch 9:9-12**

Solomon's Wealth and Spendor

13The weight of gold that came to Solomon each year was 25 tons [666 talents] **14**besides what traders and merchants brought, and besides the gold and silver the kings of Arabia and the governors of the country brought. **15**King Solomon made 200 large shields of beaten gold, using 15 lbs [600 shekels] of beaten gold on each one. **16**He made 300 shields of beaten gold, using 7½ lbs [300 shekels] of gold on each one. He put them in the Palace of the Forest of Lebanon. **17**He made a large throne out of ivory and overlaid it with pure gold. **18**It had 6 steps leading up to it, a gold footstool attached to it, arms on each side of the seat, and 2 lions standing beside the arms. **19**12 lions stood on opposite sides of the 6 steps. Nothing like it was ever made for any other kingdom. **20**King Solomon's drinking cups were made out of gold. The items for the Palace of

the Forest of Lebanon were pure gold. Silver wasn't considered valuable in his time. [21]He had ships that went to Tarshish every three years with Hiram's sailors, and brought back gold, silver, ivory, apes and peacocks. **2 Ch 9:13-21**

[22]King Solomon became greater than any king *other* anywhere in wealth and wisdom. [23]Kings from all over the world wanted to be around him to hear the wisdom God put in him. [24]Each one brought his gift: silver and gold articles, clothes, weapons, spices, horses, and mules—so much a year.

[25]Solomon had 4,000 stalls for horses and chariots and 12,000 cavalry. He stationed them in the chariot cities and with him in Jerusalem. [26]He ruled the kings from the Euphrates River to the Philistine border and the border of Egypt. [27]He made silver as common as stones in Jerusalem and made cedars as plentiful as sycamores in the western foothills. [28]They brought horses for Solomon from Egypt and every country.

Summary of Solomon's Reign

[29]The rest of the acts of Solomon, first to last, are recorded in *The Chronicles of Nathan the Prophet*, *The Prophecy of Ahijah the Shilonite*, and *The Visions of Iddo the Seer* about Jeroboam Ben-Nebat. [30]He ruled for 40 years in Jerusalem over all Israel. [31]He died and they buried him in The City of David. His son Rehoboam reigned. **2 Ch 9:22-31**

The Northern Tribes Revolt

10[:1]Then **Rehoboam** went to Shechem, because Israel had come to Shechem to make him king. [2]When Jeroboam heard about it, he came back. (He was in Egypt where he'd fled from Solomon.) [3]They sent for him. When Jeroboam and all Israel came, they said to Rehoboam, [4]*"Your father made our yoke heavy. Lighten his hard service and the heavy yoke he put on us, and we'll serve you."*

[5]*"Come back in three days."*

The people left.

[6]He consulted the elders that had served his father Solomon, *"How do you advise me to answer the people?"*

[7]*"If you'll be kind to them, please them, and speak good words to them, they'll serve you permanently."*

[8]But he disregarded their advice and consulted the young men he grew up with and served him. [9]He asked them, *"What's your advice?"*

> [10]*"Tell them, 'My little finger is thicker than my father's thighs! [11]He loaded you with a heavy yoke; I'll make it heavier. He disciplined you with whips; I'll discipline you with scorpions.'"* **2 Ch 10:1-11**

12Jeroboam and the people came to Rehoboam on the third day like he'd directed them. **13**The king answered them harshly and didn't take the elders' advice. **14***"My father made your yoke heavy; I'll make it heavier. My father disciplined you with whips; I'll discipline you with scorpions."* **15**He didn't listen to the people, a turn of events Yahveh allowed with the result that he would bring about his message through Ahijah the Shilonite to Jeroboam.

16When Israel saw that the king didn't listen to them, they answered,

"What part do we have with David?
What inheritance do we have in Jesse's son?
Everybody, go home, Israel!
Look after your own house, David!"

Israel left and went home. **17**But Rehoboam ruled the Israelites in the towns in Judah. **18**He sent Hadoram, who oversaw forced labor, and the Israelites stoned him to death. King Rehoboam hurried and got in his chariot and fled to Jerusalem. **19**Israel has been in rebellion against David's dynasty ever since. **2 Ch 10:12-19**

Shemaiah's Prophecy

11:1 When Rehoboam got to Jerusalem, he gathered 180,000 soldiers from Judah and Benjamin to fight Israel to restore the kingdom to himself. **2**But a message from Yahveh came to Shemaiah, the man of God,

3*"Tell Rehoboam and all Israel in Judah and Benjamin,* **4***'Yahveh says,*
"Don't fight your kin. Go back home. I'm going to let this happen."'"

They listened to him[Y] and went back from attacking Jeroboam.

5-10 Rehoboam lived in Jerusalem and built fortified towns for defense in Judah and Benjamin: **6**Bethlehem, Etam, Tekoa, **7**Beth-zur, Soco, Adullam, **8**Gath, Mareshah, Ziph, **9**Adoraim, Lachish, Azekah, **10**Zorah, Aijalon, and Hebron. **11**He reinforced the fortresses and put officers in them along with stores of food, oil, and wine. **12**He put shields and spears in every city and reinforced them greatly. He held onto Judah and Benjamin. **2 Ch 11:1-12**

13The priests and Levites throughout Israel stood with him from all their districts. **14**The Levites abandoned their pastures and property and came to Judah and Jerusalem, because Jeroboam and his sons had excluded them from serving as priests to Yahveh. **15**He set up his own priests for the high places, satyrs, and calves he'd made. **16**People from all the tribes that set their hearts on looking to Yahveh God of Israel, followed the *priests and Levites* to Jerusalem to sacrifice to Yahveh God of their ancestors. **17**They strengthened the kingdom of Judah and supported Rehoboam for three years; they followed the way of David and Solomon.

Rehoboam's Family

[18]Then Rehoboam married Mahalath Bat-Jerimoth Ben-David and Abihail Bat-Eliab Ben-Jesse. [19]She bore him Jeush, Shemariah, and Zaham. [20]After her, he married Maacah Bat-Absalom. She bore him Abijah, Attai, Ziza, and Shelomith. [21]Rehoboam loved Maacah more than his other wives and concubines. He'd married 18 wives and 60 concubines and fathered 28 sons and 60 daughters. [22]He appointed Abijah as leader among his brothers because he intended to make him king. [23]He acted wisely and distributed some of his sons throughout Judah and Benjamin in the fortified towns, and gave them food in abundance, and sought many wives for them. **2 Ch 11:13-23**

Shishak [Shoshenq I] Invades Judah

12:[1]When Rehoboam's kingdom got secure and strong, he and Israel turned away from the Law of Yahveh. [2]In **his fifth year**, because they weren't faithful to Yahveh, Shishak [Shoshenq I], king of Egypt, came up against Jerusalem [3]with 1,200 chariots and 60,000 horsemen. The Lybians, Sukkiim, and Nubians came with him without number. [4]He captured the fortified towns in Judah and advanced to Jerusalem. [5]Then Shemaiah the prophet came to Rehoboam and Judah's officials that had fled to Jerusalem to escape Shishak, *"Yahveh says you've left him, so he's left you to Shishak."* [6]The officials of Israel and the king humbled themselves, *"Yahveh is good."*

[7]When Yahveh saw that, he told Shemaiah,

> *"They've humbled themselves, so I won't destroy them. I'll grant them some measure of deliverance and not pour out my anger on Jerusalem by Shishak.* [8]*But they'll become his slaves so they'll learn* the difference between *serving me and serving other countries."* **2 Ch 12:1-8**

[9]Shishak [Shoshenq I] came up against Jerusalem and took the treasures out of Yahveh's Temple and the king's palace. He took everything, including the gold shields Solomon had made. [10]King Rehoboam made bronze shields to replace them and committed them to the commanders of the guard that guarded the king's palace. [11]As often as the king went into Yahveh's Temple, the guards would carry them and then bring them back to the guard room. [12]When he humbled himself, Yahveh turned his anger away, so he didn't destroy him completely. Conditions in Judah were tolerable.

[13]King Rehoboam strengthened himself in Jerusalem. He was 41 when he began to rule, and he ruled for 17 years in the city where Yahveh had chosen to identify with. *Rehoboam's* mother was Naamah the Ammonitess. [14]He did evil because he didn't set his heart to look to Yahveh. [15]The acts of Rehoboam, first to last, are recorded in *The Chronicles of Shemaiah the Prophet* and *The Chronicles of Iddo the Seer* by genealogical enrollment. There was war between Rehoboam and Jeroboam constantly. [16]Rehoboam died and they buried him in The City of David, and his son Abijah became king. **2 Ch 12:9-16**

Abijah Rules Judah

13:1In the **eighteenth year of King Jeroboam**, **Abijah** became king in Judah. 2He ruled for 3 years in Jerusalem. His mother was Micaiah Bat-Uriel of Gibeah. War arose between Abijah and Jeroboam. 3Abijah entered the battle with 400,000 trained soldiers; Jeroboam drew up in battle formation against him with 800,000 trained soldiers. **2 Ch 13:1-3**

4Abijah stood on Mount Zemaraim in the hill country of Ephraim and shouted,

> *"Jeroboam and all Israel. 5Don't you know that Yahveh God of Israel gave the rule over Israel permanently to David and his descendants by a covenant of salt? 6Yet Jeroboam rebelled against him. 7Worthless men gathered around him, scoundrels that proved to be too strong for the son of Solomon when he was young and timid and couldn't hold his own against them. 8So now you intend to resist the kingdom of Yahveh by the descendants of David because you have a big army and the golden calves Jeroboam made as <u>your</u> gods. 9Haven't you driven out Yahveh's priests, the descendants of Aaron and the Levites, and made your own priests like people in other countries? Whoever comes to consecrate himself with a young bull and seven rams, can become a priest for what aren't gods. 10Yahveh is <u>our</u> God. We haven't left him. The descendants of Aaron are serving him as priests and the Levites are doing their work. 11Every morning they burn burnt offerings and fragrant incense to him. They set the showbread on the clean table, and the golden lampstand with its lamps is ready to light every evening, because we're keeping the charge of Yahveh our God. But you've left him. 12God is at our head and his priests with the signal bugles to sound the alarm against you, Israel. Don't fight with Yahveh God of your ancestors; you won't prevail."*
>
> **2 Ch 13:4-12**

13But Jeroboam had set an ambush from the rear, so Israel lay in front of Judah and behind. 14When Judah turned around, Israel attacked them from the front and back. *Israel* cried out to Yahveh, the priests blew the bugles, 15and Judah's soldiers raised the battle cry. When they did, God routed Jeroboam and Israel in front of Abijah and Judah. 16When the Israelites fled, God delivered them to *Judah*. 17Abijah and his army defeated them with a massacre of 500,000 elite troops. 18Israel was subdued because Judah trusted in Yahveh. 19Abijah chased Jeroboam and captured several towns: Bethel, Jeshanah, and Ephron with their villages. 20Jeroboam didn't regain strength during Abijah's reign. Yahveh struck him, and he died.

21Abijah became more powerful and took 14 wives and became father of 22 sons and 16 daughters. 22The rest of the acts of Abijah, his ways and words, are recorded in *The Account of the Prophet Iddo*. **2 Ch 13:13-22**

14:1 When Abijah died, they buried him in The City of David, and his son **Asa** became king. The country had peace for 10 years.

Asa Rules Judah

2Asa did what was good. **3**He removed the foreign altars and high places, tore down the scared pillars, cut down the Asherah poles, **4**and commanded Judah to look to Yahveh God of their ancestors and to observe the Law and the commandments. **5**He removed the high places and incense altars from the towns in Judah. **6**He built fortified towns in Judah since Yahveh had given the country rest. **7**He said to Judah,

> *"Let's build these towns and surround them with walls and towers, gates and bars. The country is still ours because we've sought Yahveh, and he's given us rest all around."*

They built and prospered. **8**Asa had a standing army of 300,000 from Judah that carried spears and large shields and 280,000 from Benjamin that carried shields and handled bows—fearless soldiers. **2 Ch 14:1-8**

9Now Zerah the Nubian came out against them at Mareshah with 1,000,000 men and 300 chariots. **10**Asa went out to engage him. They drew up in battle formation in the Valley of Zaphathah at Mareshah. **11**Asa called to Yahveh,

> *"No one but you can help us in this battle of the weak against the strong. You're our God. Help us against this army. Don't let any mortal prevail against you."*

12Yahveh routed the Nubians in front of Asa and Judah. **13**Asa and the people chased them as far as Gerar. So many Nubians fell that they couldn't recover. Yahveh and his army shattered them. Judah carried away a lot of plunder. **14**They destroyed the towns around Gerar because the dread of Yahveh had fallen on them. They plundered them all, a lot of plunder. **15**They also struck down the livestock owners and took away large numbers of sheep and camels. Then they went back to Jerusalem. **2 Ch 14:9-15**

Asa's Reforms

15:1 The Spirit of God came on Azariah Ben-Oded, **2**and he went out to meet Asa,

> *"Listen, Asa, Judah, and Benjamin, Yahveh is with you when you're with him. If you look for him, he'll let you find him. If you leave him, he'll leave you.* **3***For a long time Israel was without the true God, without a teaching priest, without law.* **4***But in their distress they turned to Yahveh and looked for him, and he let them find him.* **5***In those times, there wasn't any peace to the ones who traveled; disturbances troubled the people in many countries.* **6***Nation crushed*

nation, city crushed city, because God distressed them with all kinds of problems.
7*But you, be strong. Don't lose courage; there's reward for your work."*

8When Asa heard Azariah's prophecy, he gathered the courage to remove the detestable idols from Judah and Benjamin and the towns he'd captured in the hill country of Ephraim. He restored Yahveh's altar that was in front of the vestibule. **9**He gathered Judah, Benjamin, and people from Ephraim, Manasseh, and Simeon that lived with them; because many had defected to him from Israel when they saw Yahveh was with him. **10**They came together at Jerusalem in **the third month of Asa's fifteenth year**. **11**That day they sacrificed 700 oxen and 7,000 sheep from the spoils they'd brought. **12**They entered into a covenant to look to Yahveh God of their ancestors with all their heart and soul. **13**Whoever wouldn't look to him[Y] would be executed, man or woman, great or small. **14**In addition, they shouted an oath to Yahveh with trumpets and rams' horns. **15**Judah celebrated the oath, because they'd sworn with all their heart and sought him earnestly, and he let them find him. Yahveh gave them rest in every direction. **2 Ch 15:1-15**

16*Asa* even removed his mother Maacah from being queen mother, because she'd set up a detestable Asherah pole. Asa cut it down, pulverized it, and burned it at the Brook Kidron. **17**He did not remove the high places from Israel, but his heart was blameless his whole life. **18**He brought to God's Temple his and his fathers' dedicated things: silver, gold, and *various* articles. **19**There wasn't any war till his thirty-fifth year. **2 Ch 15:16-19**

Asa's Final Years

16:1 In **the thirty-sixth year of Asa's reign**, Baasha, king of Israel, came up against Judah and fortified Ramah to prevent anyone from going out or coming in to Asa. **2**Asa brought out silver and gold from the treasuries of Yahveh's Temple and the king's palace, and sent them to Benhadad, king of Aram, who lived in Damascus, and said, **3***"Let's make a treaty between us, like the one between our fathers. I've sent you silver and gold; go break your treaty with Baasha so he'll withdraw from me."* **4**Benhadad listened and sent his armies against the towns in Israel. They conquered Ijon, Dan, Abel-maim, and the store towns in Naphtali. **5**When Baasha heard about it, he stopped fortifying Ramah. **6**Then King Asa brought Judah, and they carried away the stones and timber from Ramah that Baasha had been using, and with them *Asa* fortified Geba and Mizpah. **2 Ch 16:1-6**

7At that time, Hanani the seer came to Asa,

> *"Because you've relied on the king of Aram instead of me, his army has escaped.* **8***Weren't the Nubians and Lybians an immense army with lots of chariots and horsemen? Yet because you relied on Yahveh, he delivered them to you.* **9***His[Y] eyes scan over the world so he can strongly support the ones whose hearts are completely his. You've acted foolishly in this. From now on you'll have wars."*

[10]Asa was mad at the seer for saying that and put him in stocks in prison. At the same time, he perpetrated cruelties on some of the people.

[11]The acts of Asa, first to last, are recorded in *The Book of the Kings of Judah and Israel.* [12]In the **thirty-ninth year of his reign**, Asa got a serious infection in his feet; yet even in his disease he didn't look to Yahveh but to doctors. [13]He died in the **forty-first year** of his reign. [14]They buried him in a tomb he'd hewn out for himself in The City of David. They laid him on a bier he'd filled with various spices prepared by incense makers. They built a big fire in his honor. **2 Ch 16:7-14**

Jehoshaphat Rules Judah

17:[1]His son **Jehoshaphat** became king and secured his position against Israel. [2]He placed troops in Judah's fortified towns and set garrisons in Judah and the towns in Ephraim his father had captured. [3]Yahveh was with him because he followed his ancestor David's earlier days and didn't look to the images of Baal. [4]He sought his father's God, followed his commandments, and didn't do like Israel. [5]Yahveh secured the kingdom under him, Judah brought tributes to him, and he had great wealth and honor. [6]He took pride in the ways of Yahveh and removed again the high places and Asherah poles from Judah.

[7]In **his third year**, he sent his officials Benhail, Obadiah, Zechariah, Nethanel, and Micaiah to teach in the towns in Judah. [8]He sent with them Shemaiah, Nethaniah, Zebadiah, Asahel, Shemiramoth, Jehonathan, Adonijah, Tobijah, and Tobadonijah, who were Levites, and with them the priests Elishama and Jehoram. [9]They taught the people throughout Judah, having the Book of the Law with them. **2 Ch 17:1-9**

[10]The kingdoms around Judah dreaded Yahveh; so they didn't start any wars with Jehoshaphat. [11]Some Philistines brought him gifts and silver as tribute. The Arabians brought him 7,700 rams and 7,700 male goats. [12]He grew greater and greater, and built fortresses and store towns in Judah. [13]He had large supplies in the towns in Judah, and trained soldiers in Jerusalem. [14]This was their muster according to their families:

Judah had commanders of thousands; Adnah *was* the commander with 300,000 soldiers.

[15]Beside him *was* Johanan the commander with 280,000.

[16]Beside him *was* Amasiah Ben-Zichri, who volunteered for Yahveh, with 200,000 trained soldiers.

[17]In Benjamin, Eliada a fearless soldier, had 200,000 armed with bow and shield.

[18]Beside him *was* Jehozabad with 180,000 equipped for war.

[19]Those served the king, not counting the ones he put in the fortified towns all around Judah.

2 Ch 17:10-19

Jehoshaphat and Ahab

18:1Jehoshaphat had great wealth and honor, and allied himself by marriage with Ahab.
2Some years later he went down to visit Ahab in Samaria. Ahab slaughtered lots of sheep and
oxen for him and the people with him, and induced him to go up against Ramoth-gilead. 3He
asked Jehoshaphat, *"Will you go with me against Ramoth-gilead?"*

He told him, *"I'm like you, my people like yours. We'll go with you into the battle."*

4In addition, he said, *"First let's ask for a message from Yahveh."* 5He gathered the
prophets, 400 men, and asked, *"Should we attack Ramoth-gilead?"* They said, *"Go up. God will
deliver it to you."*

6But Jehoshaphat asked, *"Isn't there still a Yahveh prophet here that we can ask?"*

7*Ahab* told him, *"There's one, Micaiah Ben-Imla, but I despise the guy; he never
prophesies anything good about me."*

But Jehoshaphat said, *"Don't say that."* **2 Ch 18:1-7**

Micaiah's Prophecy Against Ahab

8The king of Israel called an officer and said, *"Quick, bring Micaiah Ben-Imla."* 9The
two kings were sitting on their thrones, arrayed in their robes, at the threshing floor by the
entrance to the gate of Samaria, and the prophets were prophesying in front of them. 10Zedekiah
Ben-Chenaanah made iron horns and said, *"Yahveh says you'll gore the Arameans with these till
they're consumed."* 11The prophets kept prophesying, *"Go up to Ramoth-gilead and prevail.
Yahveh will deliver it to you."*

12The messenger that went to summon Micaiah told him, *"The prophets are all speaking
favorably for the king; so please say what they're saying."*

13*"As sure as Yahveh lives, I'll say what my God says."* **2 Ch 18:8-13**

14When he came, the king said, *"Should we attack Ramoth-gilead?"*

"Go right on up there! Prevail! Yahveh is going to <u>*deliver*</u> *it to you for sure!!"*

15The king said, *"How many times do I have to demand that you not tell me anything but
the truth in Yahveh's name?"*

16So he said,

"I saw Israel scattered on the mountains
like sheep without a shepherd.
Yahveh said,
'These don't have a master;
they need to go home in peace.'"

17*Ahab* said, *"Didn't I tell you he wouldn't prophesy anything good about me?"*

18Micaiah said,

*"Listen to Yahveh's message. I saw him sitting on his throne, and the host
of heaven was standing on his right and left. 19He said, 'Who will lure Ahab into
going up and falling at Ramoth-gilead?'*

"One said one thing, another said another.
20 *"Then a spirit came forward and said, 'I'll do it.'*
'How?'
21 *'I'll be a deceiving spirit in his prophets.'*
'Go do it.'
22 *Yahveh has put a deceiving spirit in your prophets and declared disaster on you."* **2 Ch 18:14-22**

23 Then Zedekiah Ben-Chenaanah came and hit Micaiah on the cheek and said, *"How did the Spirit of Yahveh leave me to speak to you?"*
24 *"You'll see when you go hide in an inner room."*
25 The king said,
"Take Micaiah back to Amon, governor of the city, and to my son Joash.
26 *Tell them to put him in prison and feed him sparingly with bread and water till I come back safely."*
27 Micaiah said, *"If you come back safely, Yahveh hasn't spoken by me. You all need to listen."* **2 Ch 18:23-27**

The Death of Ahab

28 The king of Israel and Jehoshaphat went on up against Ramoth-gilead. **29** *Ahab* said to Jehoshaphat, *"I'll disguise myself and go into battle, but you put on your robes."* The king disguised himself, and they went into battle. **30** The king of Aram had told the captains of his chariots, *"Don't fight anybody great or small, just the king of Israel."* **31** When the captains of the chariots saw Jehoshaphat, they shouted, *"It's the king of Israel!"* They turned aside to attack him. But Jehoshaphat cried out, and Yahveh helped him by diverting them away. **32** When the captains saw it wasn't *Ahab*, they quit chasing him. **33** A man drew his bow at random and struck the king of Israel in a joint in the armor. He told the chariot driver, *"Turn around, and get me out of the fight. I'm seriously wounded."* **34** The battle raged that day, and the king of Israel propped himself up in his chariot in front of the Arameans till evening. He died at sundown. **2 Ch 18:28-34**

Jehoshaphat Appoints Judges

19:1 Jehoshaphat went back safely to his palace in Jerusalem. **2** Jehu Ben-Hanani the seer went out to meet him and said,
"Should you help the sinful, love the ones that hate Yahveh, and bring his wrath on you? **3** *But there's some good in you: you've removed the Asherah poles from the country and set your heart to look to God."*

[4]Jehoshaphat lived in Jerusalem, circulated again among the people from Beersheba to the hill country of Ephraim, and brought them back to Yahveh God of their ancestors. [5]He appointed judges in each fortified city in Judah,

> [6]*"Consider what you're doing. You're not* just *judging for people but for Yahveh that's with you.* [7]*Respect him; he won't take part in sin, partiality, or bribery."* **2 Ch 19:1-7**

[8]In Jerusalem, Jehoshaphat appointed Levites, priests, and heads of families to judge disputes,

> [9]*"Do this in respect for Yahveh, faithfully and wholeheartedly.* [10]*Whenever a dispute comes to you from your relatives that live in their cities, between blood and blood, between law and commandment, statutes and ordinances, warn them so they won't be guilty to Yahveh and wrath won't come on you or them.* [11]*Amariah the chief priest will manage everything that has to do with Yahveh. Zebadiah Ben-Ishmael, ruler of Judah, will manage everything that has to do with the king. The Levites will be officers in your presence. Act resolutely; Yahveh be with the godly."* **2 Ch 19:8-11**

Jehoshaphat Defeats Moab and Ammon

20:[1]After that, the Moabites, Ammonites, and some Meunites came to attack Jehoshaphat. [2]Some people brought him a report, *"A large army is coming out of Edom from the other side of the sea. They're in Hazazon-tamar (En-gedi)."* [3]He was afraid, set himself to look to Yahveh, and declared a fast throughout Judah. [4]Judah gathered from all the towns to look to Yahveh for help. **2 Ch 20:1-4**

[5]Jehoshaphat stood in the assembly of Judah and Jerusalem, in Yahveh's Temple in front of the new court,

> [6]*"Yahveh our ancestors' God, aren't you God in the sky? Don't you rule every nation? You have such power and strength that nobody can stand against you.* [7]*Didn't you drive out the people in this land, and give it to the descendants of Abraham your friend forever?* [8]*They've lived in it, built a sanctuary there for your name, and said,* [9]*'Should misfortune come on us—the sword, judgment, disease, or famine—we'll present ourselves at this Temple (because your name is here), and call out to you in our distress. You'll hear us and deliver us.* [10]*You didn't let Israel invade the Ammonites, Moabites, or Mount Seir when they came out of Egypt. (They turned aside and didn't destroy them.)* [11]*Now they're rewarding us by coming to drive us out of the possession you gave us.* [12]*Our God, won't you judge them? We're powerless in the face of such a big army. We don't know what to do but look to you* for help.*"* **2 Ch 20:5-12**

13All Judah was standing before Yahveh with their infants, wives, and children.

14Then in the assembly, the Spirit of Yahveh came on Jahaziel Ben-Zechariah (Ben-Benaiah Ben-Jeiel Ben-Mattaniah the Levite, descendant of Asaph),

> **15** *"Listen, Judah, people in Jerusalem, King Jehoshaphat. Yahveh says, 'Don't be afraid or intimidated by that big army. The battle is not yours but mine.* **16***Go down against them tomorrow. They'll come up by the ascent of Ziz. You'll find them at the end of the valley east of the Wilderness of Jeruel.* **17***You won't* need *to fight in this* battle*. Take your positions. Stand and watch my*[Y] *salvation for you.' Don't be afraid or intimidated. Go out to face them tomorrow; Yahveh's with you."*

18Jehoshaphat bowed to the ground, and Judah and the people in Jerusalem fell down in worship to Yahveh. **19**The Levites from the Kohathites and Korahites stood up to give loud praise to[Y] God of Israel. **2 Ch 20:13-19**

20They got up early the next morning and went out to the Wilderness of Tekoa. As they went, Jehoshaphat stood and said, *"Judah and Jerusalem, trust Yahveh and you'll be safe. Trust his prophets and you'll succeed."* **21**When he'd advised the people, he appointed the ones that sang and praised Yahveh in holy attire to go out ahead of the army, *"Thank Yahveh because his love endures forever."* **22**When they began singing and praising, he[Y] set ambushes against the Ammonites, Moabites, and Mount Seir; and they were routed. **23**The Ammonites and Moabites attacked the people from Mount Seir and destroyed them completely. When they'd finished that, they helped destroy one another.

24When Judah came to the watchtower over the countryside, they looked toward the army. Corpses were lying everywhere; nobody had escaped. **25**When Jehoshaphat and his people came to take their spoil, they found lots of equipment, clothes, and valuable things, more than they could carry. They took spoil for three days, there was so much of it. **26**On the fourth day, they met in the Valley of Beracah to "bless" Yahveh. That's still its name. **27**Everyone in Judah and Jerusalem came back happy with Jehoshaphat in the lead, because Yahveh made them celebrate over their enemies. **28**They came to Jerusalem to the[Y] Temple with harps, lyres, and trumpets. **29**All the kingdoms dreaded God when they heard that he[Y] had fought Israel's enemies. **30**Jehoshaphat's kingdom had peace because his God gave him rest in every direction.

2 Ch 20:20-30

Summary of Jehoshaphat's Reign

31Jehoshaphat was 35 when he became king and ruled Judah in Jerusalem for 25 years. His mother was Azubah Bat-Shilhi. **32**He followed the way of his father Asa. He did what was good, **33**but he didn't take away the high places. The people hadn't yet directed their hearts to their ancestors' God. **34**The rest of the acts of Jehoshaphat, first to last, are recorded in *The Chronicles of Jehu Ben-Hanani* and *The Book of the Kings of Israel*.

[35]After that, Jehoshaphat allied himself with Ahaziah, king of Israel. That was a bad decision. [36]He did it to build ships in Ezion-geber for going to Tarshish. [37]Then Eliezer Ben-Dodavahu from Mareshah prophesied against him, *"Because you've allied yourself with Ahaziah, Yahveh has destroyed what you've built."* **2 Ch 20:31-37**

Jehoram Rules Judah

21:[1]Jehoshaphat died, and they buried him in The City of David. His son **Jehoram** became king. [2]His brothers were Azariah, Jehiel, Zechariah, Azariyahu, Michael, and Shephatiah. [3]Their father had given them many gifts of silver, gold, and *other* precious things along with fortified towns in Judah. But he gave the kingdom to Jehoram, his firstborn.

[4]When Jehoram had taken over the kingdom and made himself secure, he killed his brothers with the sword and some of the rulers too. [5]He was 32 when he became king and ruled for 8 years in Jerusalem. [6]He followed the ways of Israel's kings like Ahab's house did. (His wife was Ahab's daughter.) He did evil, [7]but because of his covenant with David, Yahveh wouldn't destroy David's house. He'd promised to give him and his descendants a lamp permanently. **2 Ch 21:1-7**

[8]During his reign Edom revolted and set up its own king. [9]So Jehoram crossed over with his commanders and all his chariots. He got up at night and struck down the Edomites and the commanders of the chariots that were surrounding him. [10]But Edom is still independent from Judah.

Libnah revolted at the same time because Jehoram had left Yahveh God of his ancestors. [11]Besides, he made high places in the mountains in Judah, and led the people in Jerusalem to carry on *religious* prostitution.

[12]Elijah the prophet sent him a letter:

> *"Yahveh, God of your ancestor David, says, 'You've not followed the ways of Jehoshaphat your father and Asa king of Judah.* [13]*You've followed the kings of Israel and made Judah and Israel carry on* religious *prostitution like Ahab's house did. You've even killed your own brothers, who were better than you.* [14]*I'm*^{Y} *going to strike your people, your sons, your wives, and everything you own with catastrophe.* [15]*You'll suffer with a severe intestinal disease till your bowels come out.'"* **2 Ch 21:8-15**

[16]Then Yahveh stirred up the Philistines and Arabs that bordered the Nubians. [17]They invaded Judah and carried away everything in the king's palace, including his sons and wives. He didn't have any son left except Jehoahaz, the youngest.

[18]In addition, Yahveh struck him with an incurable disease. [19]In two years, his bowels came out, and he died in severe pain. His people made no fire for him like they did for his ancestors. [20]He died with nobody's regret. They buried him in The City of David, but not in the tombs of the kings. **2 Ch 21:16-20**

Ahaziah Rules Judah

22:[1]Then the people in Jerusalem made **Ahaziah**/*Jehoahaz*, his youngest son, king. The band of men that came with the Arabs to the camp had killed the older sons. [2]Ahaziah was 22 and ruled for 1 year in Jerusalem. His mother was Athaliah, granddaughter of Omri. [3]To his destruction, he also followed Ahab's practices because his mother gave him bad counsel. [4]He sinned in [5]going with Jehoram Ben-Ahab to fight Hazael, king of Aram, at Ramoth-gilead. But the Arameans wounded *Joram*/Jehoram. [6]He came back to heal in Jezreel from his wounds at Ramah. Ahaziah Ben-*Joram*/Jehoram, king of Judah, went down to see *Joram*/Jehoram in Jezreel because he was wounded. **2 Ch 22:1-6**

[7]The destruction of Ahaziah was from God for going to Joram/*Jehoram*. He went out with Jehoram against Jehu Ben-Nimshi that Yahveh had anointed to eliminate Ahab's family. [8]When Jehu was executing judgment on that house, he found the officials of Judah and the sons of Ahaziah's brothers serving Ahaziah and killed them. [9]His men also looked for Ahaziah and caught him hiding in Samaria. They brought him to Jehu, put him to death, and buried him; because they said, *"He <u>is</u> the son of Jehoshaphat, who sought Yahveh with all his heart."* There wasn't anybody from Ahaziah's family capable of ruling the kingdom.

Queen Athaliah Rules Judah

[10]When his mother Athaliah saw he was dead, she killed the royal offspring in Judah. [11]But Jehoshabeath, King *Joram*/Jehoram's daughter, stole Joash Ben-Ahaziah from among the king's sons—who were being murdered—and placed him and his nurse in a bedroom. Jehoshabeath, wife of Jehoiada the priest and Ahaziah's sister, hid him so Athaliah couldn't kill him. [12]They hid him in God's Temple for 6 years while **Athaliah** ruled the country. **2 Ch 22:7-12**

Revolt Against Athaliah

23:[1]In the **seventh year**, Jehoiada summoned the courage to make a pact with the commanders of hundreds: Azariah Ben-*Joram*/Jeroham, Ishmael Ben-Johanan, Azariah Ben-Obed, Maaseiah Ben-Adaiah, and Elishaphat Ben-Zichri. [2]They gathered to Jerusalem the Levites from the towns in Judah and the heads of families. [3]When the assembly made a pact with the king in God's Temple, Jehoiada told them,

> *"The king's son will reign like Yahveh has said regarding David's descendants. [4]A third of you, priests and Levites that come in on the Sabbath, will*

be gatekeepers. [5]A third will be at the king's palace, and a third at the Foundation Gate. The people will be in the courts of the[Y] Temple. [6]Don't let anybody go into the[Y] Temple except the priests and servicing Levites. They can go in because they're holy. Have the people keep the charge of Yahveh. [7]The Levites will surround the king with weapons in hand. Kill whoever comes into the Temple. Be with the king when he comes in and goes out."

[8]The Levites and Judah did what he said. Each one brought his men that were to come in on the Sabbath with the ones that were to go out on the Sabbath, because Jehoiada didn't dismiss any of the divisions. [9]Jehoiada gave the commanders of hundreds King David's spears and large and small shields that were in the Temple. [10]He stationed the men around the king from the south side of the Temple to the north, near the altar. [11]Then they brought out the king's son, put the crown on him, gave him the Testimony, and declared him king. Jehoiada and his sons anointed him and said, *"Long live the king!"* **2 Ch 23:1-11**

The Death of Athaliah

[12]When Athaliah heard people running and praising the king, she came into the[Y] Temple. [13]She saw the king standing by his pillar at the entrance, and the commanders and trumpeters beside him. The common people were celebrating and blowing trumpets. The singers with their musical instruments were leading the praise. She tore her clothes, *"Treason! Treason!"* [14]Jehoiada brought out the commanders over the army and told them, *"Bring her out between the ranks and put to death with a sword anybody that tries to rescue her."* The priests said, *"Don't do it in the[Y] Temple."* [15]They seized her, and when she got to the entrance of the Horse Gate of the king's palace, they put her to death. **2 Ch 23:12-15**

Jehoiadah's Reforms

[16]Jehoiada made a covenant with the people and the king that they'd be Yahveh's people. [17]The people tore down Baal's temple, broke his altars and images into pieces, and killed Mattan his priest by the altars. [18]He placed the officers of the[Y] Temple under the Levitical priests that David had assigned over the[Y] Temple, as written in the Law of Moses—with celebration and singing according to David's order. [19]He stationed gatekeepers for the[Y] Temple so nobody ceremonially unclean could go in. [20]He took the commanders of hundreds, the nobles, rulers of the people, and common people, and brought the king down from the[Y] Temple through the upper gate to the king's palace and placed him on the throne. [21]So the people celebrated, and the city grew quiet because they'd put Athaliah to death with a sword. **2 Ch 23:16-21**

Joash Repairs the Temple

24:1Joash was 7 when he became king and ruled for 40 years in Jerusalem. His mother
was Zibiah from Beersheba. 2He did what was good all the time Jehoiada was alive. 3Jehoiada
took two wives for him, and he became the father of sons and daughters.

4After that, Joash decided to restore Yahveh's Temple. 5He gathered the priests and
Levites, and said, *"Go out to the towns in Judah and collect money to repair your God's Temple annually; do it right away."* But the Levites didn't act right away. 6He summoned Jehoiada the
chief priest, *"Why haven't you required the Levites to bring in from Judah and Jerusalem the tax Moses laid on Israel for the Tent of Testimony?"* 7The sons of Athaliah had broken into God's
Temple and used the holy things for the images of Baal. **2 Ch 24:1-7**

8The king had them make a chest to set outside by the gate into Yahveh's Temple. 9They
made a proclamation in Judah and Jerusalem to bring to Yahveh the tax Moses had levied in the
desert. 10The officers and common people celebrated and brought in their levies and dropped
them in the chest till they'd finished. 11Whenever the Levites saw there was a lot in the chest,
they'd bring it to the king's officer, and his secretary and the chief priest's officer would empty it
and take it back to its place. They did that daily and collected a lot of money. 12The king and
Jehoiada gave it to the ones that serviced the[Y] Temple. They hired masons, carpenters, and
artisans in iron and bronze to repair the Temple, 13and the work progressed. They restored it to
its specifications and reinforced it. 14When they finished, they brought the rest of the money to
the king and Jehoiada. They made it into utensils for the[Y] Temple, for its service, the burnt
offering, gold and silver pans and utensils. They offered burnt offerings continually all the time
Jehoiada was alive. **2 Ch 24:8-14**

15Jehoiada died at the good old age of 130. 16They buried him in The City of David
among the kings because he'd done well in Israel for God and his Temple.

Jehoiadah's Reforms Reversed

17But after *Jehoiada's* death, the officials of Judah came and bowed to the king, and he
listened to them. 18They abandoned the Temple of Yahveh God and worshiped Asherah poles
and idols; so wrath came on Judah and Jerusalem. 19He sent prophets to bring them back to him,
but they wouldn't listen. 20Then God's Spirit came on Zechariah Ben-Jehoiada the priest. He
stood above the people and said*, "God says, 'Why do you sin against Yahveh's commands and not prosper? Because you've left him, he's left you.'"* 21They plotted against him, and at the
king's command stoned him to death in the[Y] Temple court. 22So Joash the king didn't remember
the kindness *Zechariah's* father Jehoiada had shown him; he murdered his son. As he died, he
said, *"May Yahveh see and repay you!"* **2 Ch 24:15-22**

The End of Joash's Reig

23At the turn of the year, the Aramean army came up against him. They came to Judah and Jerusalem, killed the people's officials, and sent their spoil to the king in Damascus. **24**Though the Arameans came with a small army, Yahveh delivered a large army to them because they'd left him[Y]. They carried out judgment on Joash.

25They left him seriously wounded. When they'd gone, his own officials plotted against him for murdering Jehoiada's son. They assassinated him in his bed and buried him in The City of David, but not in the tombs of the kings. **26**The ones that plotted against him were Zabad Ben-Shimeath the Ammonitess and Jehozabad Ben-Shimrith the Moabitess. **27***The Commentary on the Book of the Kings* gives accounts about his sons, the many oracles against him, and the restoration of God's Temple. His son Amaziah became king. **2 Ch 24:23-27**

Amaziah Rules Judah

25:1Amaziah was 25 and ruled for 29 years in Jerusalem. His mother was Jehoaddan of Jerusalem. **2**He did what was good, but not with all *his* heart. **3**As soon as his kingdom was firmly in hand, he executed the officials that had assassinated his father. **4**He didn't put their children to death, like Yahveh commanded in the Law of Moses: *"Don't execute parents for offspring or offspring for parents. Execute each person for that person's sin."*

5Amaziah gathered Judah and appointed them according to their families under commanders of thousands and hundreds throughout Judah and Benjamin. He took a census of men 20 and older and found 300,000 elite men, fit for war and handling spear and shield. **6**He hired 100,000 trained soldiers out of Israel for 7550 lbs [100 talents] of silver. **7**But a man of God came to him and said,

> *"Don't let Israel's army go with you; Yahveh is not with Israel or Ephraim.* **8***Even if you go strong into the battle, God will still make you stumble in front of the enemy. He has power to help or hinder."*

9Amaziah said, *"But what will we do for the* 7550 lbs [100 talents] *of silver I've given Israel's troops?"*

The man of God answered, *"Yahveh has a lot more to give you than that."*
10Amaziah dismissed the troops from Ephraim, and they went home disgruntled. **`2 Ch 25:1-10**

11Amaziah gathered his courage, led his people to the Valley of Salt, and struck down 10,000 people from Seir. **12**Judah also captured 10,000 alive and brought them to the top of the cliff. They threw them down and threw them down to their death. **13**But *Israel's* troops that Amaziah sent back, raided the towns in Judah between Beth-horon and Samaria, struck down 3,000 of them, and plundered a lot of spoil.

14After Amaziah came from slaying the Edomites, he brought the gods from Seir. He set them up as gods, bowed to them, and burned incense to them. **15**Yahveh's anger burned against him. He sent him a prophet, *"Why seek gods that haven't delivered their own people from you?"*

2 Ch 25:11-15

16As he was talking to him, the king said, *"Did we appoint you a royal counselor? Shut up! Why get struck down?"*

The prophet stopped and said, *"God has planned to destroy you because you've done that and ignored my advice."*

17Amaziah took counsel and sent to Joash (Ben-Jehoahaz Ben-Jehu, king of Israel), *"Come. Let's face each other."*

18Joash sent back to him,

> *"A thistle in Lebanon sent to a cedar in Lebanon, 'Give your daughter to my son in marriage.' But a wild animal in Lebanon passed by and tramped down the thistle.* **19***You said, 'I've defeated Edom.' You've become proud. Stay home. Why stir up trouble to make yourself and Judah fall?"* **2 Ch 25:16-19**

20But Amaziah wouldn't listen because it fit with Yahveh's plan to God deliver them to *Joash* because they'd looked to Edom's gods. **21**Joash, king of Israel, went up and faced Amaziah at Beth-shemesh in Judah. **22**He defeated Judah, and they fled to their tents. **23**Joash captured Amaziah at Beth-shemesh and took him to Jerusalem. He tore down the wall from the Gate of Ephraim to the Corner Gate, 600ft. **24**He took all the gold and silver, the items in God's Temple with Obed-edom, the treasures of the king's palace, and hostages too, and went back to Samaria.

25Amaziah lived 15 years after the death of Joash Ben-Jehoahaz, king of Israel. **26**The rest of the acts of Amaziah, first to last, are recorded in *The Book of the Kings of Judah and Israel*. **27**From the time Amaziah turned away from following Yahveh, they plotted against him in Jerusalem. He fled to Lachish, but they sent assassins after him and killed him. **28**They brought him back on horses and buried him with his ancestors in The City of David[ms]. **2 Ch 25:20-28**

Uzziah Rules Judah

26:**1**The people in Judah took **Uzziah**/*Azariah* at 16 and made him king after his father Amaziah. **2**He built Eloth and restored it to Judah, **3**and ruled for 52 years in Jerusalem. His mother was Jechiliah of Jerusalem. **4**He did what was good like everything *good* his father Amaziah had done. **5**He continued to look to God in the time of Zechariah, who had understanding through the vision of God. As long as he sought Yahveh, God caused him to flourish. **2 Ch 26:1-5**

6He went out and fought the Philistines, and tore down the walls of Gath, Jabneh, and Ashdod. He built towns around Ashdod among the Philistines. **7**God helped him against the Philistines, the Arabians in Gur-baal, and the Meunites. **8**The Ammonites paid him tribute, and his reputation extended to the border of Egypt, because he became very strong. **9**In addition, he built towers in Jerusalem at the Corner Gate and the Valley Gate at the Angle, and fortified them. **10**He built towers in the countryside and hewed out many cisterns, because he had lots of

livestock in the western foothills and in the plains. He had farmers and vinedressers in the hill country and fertile fields because he loved the soil. **11**Uzziah/*Azariah* had an army ready for battle, which entered combat by divisions, according to the number of their muster, prepared by Jeiel the scribe and Maaseiah the official under the direction of Hananiah, one of the king's officers. **12**The number of family leaders over trained soldiers was 2,600. **13**They directed an elite army of 307,500 that could wage war with great power against the king's enemies. **14**For the whole army, Uzziah/*Azariah* prepared shields, spears, helmets, body armor, bows, and sling stones. **15**In Jerusalem he constructed engines of war invented by skilled men, and put them on the towers and the corners, to shoot arrows and *catapult* large stones. His reputation spread because he was marvelously helped until he became strong. **2 Ch 26:6-15**

16But when he became strong, his pride led him to act corruptly. He became unfaithful by going into Yahveh's Temple and burning incense on the incense altar. **17**Azariah the priest came in after him with 80 of the priests, brave men, **18**to oppose him,

> *"You're not supposed to burn incense. That's for the priests to do, consecrated descendants of Aaron. Get out of the sanctuary. You've been unfaithful and won't have any honor from Yahveh God."*

19But Uzziah/*Azariah*, with a censer in hand for burning incense, was mad. While he ranted at the priests, leprosy broke out on his forehead beside the altar of incense. **20**Azariah and the priests saw it and hurried him out of there. He hurried to get out himself because Yahveh had struck him. **21**For the rest of his life, he lived as a leper in a house separate from the[Y] Temple. His son Jotham managed the king's palace and judged the people. **22**The rest of the acts of Uzziah/*Azariah*, first to last, the prophet Isaiah Ben-Amoz has recorded. **23**Uzziah died, and they buried him in a burial field that the kings owned, because he was a leper. His son Jotham became king. **2 Ch 26:16-23**

Jotham Rules Judah

27:1Jotham was 25 and ruled for 16 years in Jerusalem. His mother was Jerushah Bat-Zadok. **2**He did what was good like his father, but he didn't go into the Temple. The people kept acting corruptly. **3**He built the upper gate of Yahveh's Temple and built extensively the wall of Ophel. **4**He built towns in the hill country of Judah, and fortresses and towers on the wooded hills. **5**He fought the Ammonites and prevailed; for three years they paid him 7550 lbs [100 talents] of silver, 110,000 bushels [10,000 kors] of wheat, and 110,000 bushels [10,000 *kors*] of barley a year. The Ammonites also paid that amount in the second and third years. **6**He became powerful because he ordered his ways in Yahveh his God. **7**The rest of the acts of Jotham, including his wars, are recorded in *The Book of the Kings of Israel and Judah*. [**8**] **9**He died, and they buried him in The City of David. His son Ahaz became king. **2 Ch 27:1-9**

Ahaz Rules Judah

28:1**Ahaz** was 20 and ruled for 16 years in Jerusalem. He didn't do what was good like
David did. 2He followed the kings of Israel, made molten images for worshipping Baal, 3burned
incense in the Valley of (Ben)Hinnom, and burned his sons like the nations Yahveh had driven
out. 4He sacrificed and burned incense on the high places on the hills under every green tree.

5Yahveh delivered him to the king of Aram. They defeated *Ahaz* and took a large number
of captives to Damascus. *God* also delivered him to the king of Israel, who inflicted great
casualties on him. 6Pekah Ben-Remaliah killed 120,000 in Judah in one day, all trained soldiers,
because they'd left Yahveh God of their ancestors. 7Zichri, a powerful man in Ephraim, killed
Maaseiah the king's son; Azrikam, the palace commander; and Elkanah, the king's second-in-
command. **2 Ch 28:1-7**

8Then Israel took away 200,000 women, sons, and daughters; and a great deal of spoil.
9But Yahveh's prophet Oded met the army coming to Samaria,

> *"Because Yahveh God was angry with Judah, he delivered them to you.*
> *You've killed them in a rage that has reached heaven.* 10*Now you intend to make*
> *slaves out of the men and women from Judah and Jerusalem. Don't you have*
> *sins of your own against your God?* 11*Take back the ones you've captured from*
> *your kin. Yahveh's furious anger has turned against you."*

12Some leaders of Ephraim—Azariah Ben-Johanan, Berechiah Ben-Meshillemoth,
Jehizkiah Ben-Shallum, and Amasa Ben-Hadlai—confronted those returning from battle,

> 13*"Don't bring the captives in here. You're about to bring guilt on us*
> *against Yahveh and add to our sins. We have a lot of guilt, so his furious anger*
> *has turned against us."*

14The armed men left the captives and spoil with the officers and the assembly. 15Designated
men took the captives and put clothes from the spoil on the naked ones. They gave them clothes
and sandals, fed them and gave them something to drink, put olive oil on their wounds, led their
feeble ones on donkeys, and took the captives to their fellow countrymen at Jericho, the City of
Palms. Then they came back to Samaria. **2 Ch 28:8-15**

Ahaz Closes the Temple

16At that time, King Ahaz sent to the kings of Assyria for help. 17The Edomites had
attacked Judah again and taken captives. 18The Philistines had invaded the towns in the western
foothills and the Negev of Judah, and had taken Beth-shemesh, Aijalon, Gederoth, Soco with its
villages, and settled there. 19*That was* because Yahveh humbled Judah because of Ahaz; he'd
brought about a lack of restraint in Judah and was terribly unfaithful to Yahveh. 20Tilgath-
pilneser, king of Assyria, came and attacked him instead of reinforcing him. 21Ahaz took a

portion out of Yahveh's Temple, the king's palace, and the officials' houses, and gave it to the king of Assyria; but he didn't help him. **2 Ch 28:16-21**

22In his distress, this same King Ahaz became more unfaithful to Yahveh. **23**He sacrificed to the gods of Damascus that had defeated him, *"Since the gods of Aram helped them, I'll sacrifice to them so they'll help me."* But they became the downfall of his and Israel's downfall. **24**When Ahaz gathered the utensils from God's Temple, he cut them in pieces. He closed the doors of the[Y] Temple and built altars in every corner of Jerusalem. **25**In every city in Judah he made high places to burn incense to other gods and made Yahveh angry. **26**The rest of his ways and deeds, first to last, are recorded in *The Book of the Kings of Judah and Israel*. **27**Ahaz died, and they buried him in Jerusalem but not in the tombs of the kings of Israel. His son Hezekiah reigned. **2 Ch 28:22-27**

Hezekiah Rules Judah

29:1Hezekiah became king when he was 25 and ruled for 29 years in Jerusalem. **2**He did what was right like David did.

Hezekiah Reopens the Temple

3In the **first month of his first year**, he reopened the doors of Yahveh's Temple and repaired them. **4**He brought in the priests and Levites and gathered them in the courtyard on the east. **5**He said,

> *"Listen, Levites. Consecrate yourselves and the Temple of Yahveh God of our ancestors. Remove ceremonial uncleanness from the Holy Place.* **6***Our ancestors have been unfaithful and done what he forbids. They've turned their backs on where he lives.* **7***They've shut the doors of the vestibule and put out the lamps. They haven't burned incense or offered burnt offerings in the Holy Place.* **8***So God's wrath has been against Judah and Jerusalem. He's made them something to abhor, be amazed at, hissed at, as you can see.* **9***Our ancestors fell by the sword. Our sons, daughters, and wives are in captivity because of it.* **10***I intend to renew the covenant with Yahveh God of Israel so his furious anger will turn away from us.* **11***Sons, don't neglect your responsibilities any longer. Yahveh has chosen you to stand in his presence, perform service to him and* his people*, and burn incense."* **2 Ch 29:1-11**
>
> **12**The Levites got to work:
>
> Mahath Ben-Amasai and Joel Ben-Azariah from the Kohathites;
> Kish Ben-Abdi and Azariah Ben-Jehallelel from the descendants of Merari;
> Joah Ben-Zimmah and Eden Ben-Joah from the Gershonites;
> **13**Shimri and Jeiel from the sons of Elizaphan;
> Zechariah and Mattaniah from the descendants of Asaph;

[14]Jehiel and Shimei from the descendants of Heman; and
Shemaiah and Uzziel from the sons of Jeduthun. **2 Ch 29:12-14**

[15]They gathered their relatives, consecrated themselves, and went in to cleanse Yahveh's Temple like the king said by Yahveh's words. [16]The priests went into the inner part of the Temple to cleanse it. Everything unclean they found they brought out to the court, and the Levites carried it down to the Kidron valley. [17]They began the consecration on the **first day, first month**. On the eighth day, they went into the vestibule. They consecrated Yahveh's Temple in eight days and finished on the **sixteenth**.

The Temple Rededicated

[18]Then they went in to King Hezekiah and said,

"We've cleansed the whole Temple, the altar for burnt offering with its utensils, and the table for the showbread with its utensils. [19]*We've prepared and consecrated the utensils King Ahaz discarded during his unfaithfulness. They're in front of the altar."* **2 Ch 29:15-19**

[20]Then King Hezekiah got up early and gathered the city officials and went up to Yahveh's Temple. [21]They brought seven bulls, rams, lambs, and male goats for a sin offering for the kingdom, the sanctuary, and Judah. He told the priests, descendants of Aaron, to offer them on the altar. [22]They slaughtered the bulls, rams, and lambs and sprinkled the blood on the altar. [23]They brought the male goats for the sin offering in the presence of the king and the assembly, and laid their hands on them. [24]The priests slaughtered them and purged the altar with their blood to atone for Israel, because the king ordered the burnt offering and the sin offering for all Israel.

[25]Then he stationed the Levites in Yahveh's Temple with cymbals, harps, and lyres like David, Gad the seer, and Nathan the prophet had commanded. The command came from Yahveh through his prophets. [26]The Levites stood with David's musical instruments and the priests with *their* trumpets. [27]Hezekiah gave the order to offer the burnt offering on the altar. When the burnt offering began, the song to Yahveh also began with the trumpets accompanied by David's instruments. [28]While the whole assembly worshiped, the singers sang and the trumpets blew till the burnt offering finished. [29]Then the king and everybody present with him bowed in worship. [30]King Hezekiah and the officials directed the Levites to sing praises to Yahveh with the words of David and Asaph the seer. They sang praises with joy and bowed in worship. **2 Ch 29:20-30**

[31]Hezekiah said, *"Now that you've consecrated yourselves, come near and bring sacrifices and thank offerings to Yahveh's Temple."* The assembly brought sacrifices and thank offerings, and everybody that wanted to brought burnt offerings. [32]The assembly brought 70 bulls, 100 rams, and 200 lambs as burnt offerings. [33]The consecrated things were 600 bulls and 3,000 sheep. [34]There weren't enough priests to skin all the burnt offerings. So their relatives the Levites helped them till they finished and *more* priests had consecrated themselves. The Levites

were more conscientious about consecrating themselves than the priests were. **35**Besides the large number of burnt offerings, there was the fat of the peace offerings and the liquid offerings for the burnt offerings. In that way, they restored the service in Yahveh's Temple. **36**Then Hezekiah and the people celebrated what God had prepared for them, because the thing had come about suddenly. **2 Ch 29:31-36**

Hezekiah Celebrates the Passover

30:**1**Hezekiah wrote letters to everywhere in Israel and Judah, to Ephraim and Manasseh to come to Yahveh's Temple in Jerusalem, to keep Passover to the God of Israel. **2**The king, his official, and the whole assembly in Jerusalem had decided to keep Passover in the second month. **3**They couldn't keep it at its regular time because the priests hadn't sanctified themselves in sufficient numbers, and the people hadn't gathered in Jerusalem. **4**The plan seemed right to the king and the whole assembly. **5**They circulated a proclamation from Dan to Beersheba to come and keep Passover at Jerusalem; they hadn't kept it in great numbers as written. **6**So runners went everywhere in Israel and Judah with letters from the king and his officials:

> *"People of Israel, come back to Yahveh God of Abraham, Isaac, and Israel so he'll come back to the remnant of you that have escaped from the kings of Assyria.* **7***Don't be like your ancestors and fellow Jews that weren't faithful to him. He made them desolate, as you can see.* **8***Don't stiffen your neck like they did. Yield to him and go into the sanctuary he's consecrated permanently. Serve him so his furious anger will turn away from you.* **9***If you come back to him, your fellow Jews and descendants will receive mercy from their captors and come back to this land. Yahveh is gracious and merciful. He won't turn away from you if you come back to him."* **2 Ch 30:1-9**

10Runners went from city to city throughout Ephraim and Manasseh and as far as Zebulun, but the people scorned and mocked them. **11**Only a few from Asher, Manasseh, and Zebulun humbled themselves and came. **12**God's hand was on Judah to give them a united heart to do what the king and his officials said.

13A really large assembly came together in Jerusalem to keep the Festival of Unleavened Bread in the second month. **14**They removed the altars in the city, took away the incense altars, and threw them in the Kidron valley. **15**They killed the Passover lamb on the fourteenth day, second month. The priests and Levites were ashamed; so they sanctified themselves and brought burnt offerings to Yahveh's Temple. **16**They took their accustomed stations according to the Law of Moses, the man of God. The priests sprinkled the blood they received from the Levites **17**because many in the assembly hadn't sanctified themselves. To make the Passover lamb holy

to Yahveh, the Levites had to kill it for everybody that wasn't clean. **18**A great number of people, many of them from Ephraim, Manasseh, Issachar, and Zebulun, hadn't purified themselves; yet they ate the Passover other than as prescribed. Hezekiah had prayed for them,

> *"The good Yahveh pardon everybody* **19***that sets his heart to look to you*[Y]*, even though not according to the sanctuary's rules for cleanness."* **2 Ch 30:10-19**

20Yahveh listened to Hezekiah and purified them. **21**The people present in Jerusalem kept the Festival of Unleavened Bread for a week with great celebration. The Levites and priests praised Yahveh daily, singing to him with all their energy. **22**Hezekiah encouraged the Levites that showed skill in serving Yahveh. The people observed the festival for a week, sacrificing peace offerings and giving thanks to Yahveh.

23Then the whole assembly agreed to keep the festival for another week with happiness, **24**because Hezekiah gave the assembly 1,000 bulls and 7,000 sheep for offerings. The officials gave the assembly 1,000 bulls and 10,000 sheep. The priests sanctified themselves in great numbers. **25**The whole assembly celebrated—the ones from Judah, the priests and Levites, the ones that came out of Israel, the temporary residents in Israel and Judah. **26**There was great celebrating in Jerusalem; since Solomon's time, nothing like this had happened there. **27**Then the priests and Levites got up and blessed the people, and *Yahveh* heard them. Their prayer went up to the Holy Place where he lives in heaven. **2 Ch 30:20-27**

Hezekiah's Reforms

31:1 When that finished, Israel went out and broke down the pillars in pieces, cut down the Asherah poles, pulled down the high places and altars, and destroyed them everywhere in Judah and Benjamin, Ephraim and Manasseh. Then they returned to their towns and properties.

2Hezekiah appointed the divisions of priests and Levites, according to each one's service: for burnt offerings and peace offerings, to minister, give thanks and praise in the camp of Yahveh. **3**He also appointed the kings' portion of goods for the burnt offerings—for the morning and evening burnt offerings, the Sabbaths, new moons, and fixed festivals like the Law says. **4**He commanded the people in Jerusalem to give the portion due to the priests and Levites so they could devote themselves to the Law of Yahveh. **5**As soon as the order spread, the Israelites provided in abundance a tenth of the first part of the harvest of grain, new wine, oil, honey, and produce. **6**The ones that lived in the towns in Judah also brought in a tenth of the oxen and sheep, and a tenth of the sacred gifts consecrated to Yahveh and placed *them* in piles. **7**In the third month, they began to make the piles and finished them by the seventh. **8**When Hezekiah and the rulers came and saw the piles, they blessed Yahveh and his people. **9**Hezekiah asked the chief priests and Levites about the piles. **10**Azariah, the chief priest from the House of Zadok, said,

"Since the contributions started coming to Yahveh's Temple, we've had enough to eat with this amount left over. He has blessed his people." **2 Ch 31:1-10**

11Then Hezekiah told them to prepare rooms in the[Y] Temple. **12**They faithfully brought in the contributions, tenths, and consecrated things.

Conaniah the Levite had charge of them; his brother Shimei was second in rank.

13Jehiel, Azaziah, Nahath, Asahel, Jerimoth, Jozabad, Eliel, Ismachiah, Mahath, and Benaiah were overseers under Conaniah and Shimei his brother.

Azariah was the chief officer for God's Temple.

14Kore Ben-Imnah the Levite, keeper of the eastern gate, oversaw the freewill offerings and apportioned the contributions for Yahveh and the most holy things. **2 Ch 31:11-14**

15Eden, Miniamin, Jeshua, Shemaiah, Amariah, and Shecaniah assisted him in the priestly towns to distribute faithfully the portions to their fellow Jews by divisions, young and old alike. **16**Without regard to their genealogical enrollment, *they were to do it* for males 30 and older for their duties in their divisions—everybody that entered Yahveh's Temple for his daily obligations. **17***They were to do it* as well to the priests genealogically enrolled by families, and the Levites 20 years and older, according to their duties and divisions. **18**The genealogical enrollment included their little children, wives, sons, and daughters for the whole assembly, because they consecrated themselves faithfully in holiness. **19**For the descendants of Aaron (the priests that were in their towns' pastures or in each city), there were men designated to distribute portions to every male among the priests and to everybody genealogically enrolled among the Levites.

20Hezekiah did that throughout Judah. What he did was good, right, and true in front of Yahveh. **21**He looked to his God, in the service of God's Temple in law and commandment, and did everything with all his heart and succeeded. **2 Ch 31:15:21**

Assyria Invades Judah

32:1 After those faithful acts, Sennacherib, king of Assyria, invaded Judah, laid siege to fortified towns, and intended to break into them. **2**When Hezekiah saw he'd come and meant to attack Jerusalem, **3**he, his officers, and soldiers decided to cut off the water supply from the springs outside the city. **4**Many people came together and stopped up the springs feeding the stream that flowed through the region, *"Why should Assyria's kings come and find abundant water?"* **5**He took courage and rebuilt the wall that had been torn down, erected towers on it, built an outside wall, strengthened the Millo in The City of David, and made a great number of weapons and shields. **6**He appointed military officers over the people, and gathered them in the square at the city gate to encourage them,

7*"Be strong and courageous; don't be afraid or intimidated by Assyria's king or his host. The One that's with us is greater than the one that's with him.*

> [8]*All he's got is a physical army, but we have Yahveh our God to help us and fight our battles."*

The people trusted what he said. **2 Ch 32:1-8**

Sennacherib Threatens Jerusalem

[9]After that, Sennacherib sent officers to Jerusalem while he was laying siege to Lachish with his forces. *He sent them* against Hezekiah and all Judah that were in Jerusalem,

> [10]*"Sennacherib, king of Assyria, says, 'What are you trusting in that you stay in Jerusalem under siege?* [11]*Isn't Hezekiah misleading you to give yourselves over to die by hunger and thirst, and saying Yahveh your God will deliver you from the king of Assyria?* [12]*Hasn't the same Hezekiah taken away his high places and altars, and told Judah and Jerusalem to worship at one altar and burn incense on it?* [13]*Don't you know what my predecessors and I have done to all the countries? Were their gods able to deliver their land from me?* [14]*Who among them that my predecessors destroyed, could deliver his people from me?* [15]*Don't let Hezekiah mislead you. No god could deliver his people from me and the kings before me. How much less your God?'"* **2 Ch 32:9-15**

[16]His officers spoke against Yahveh God and Hezekiah. [17]He wrote letters to insult Yahveh God of Israel:

> *"None of the nations' gods have delivered their people from me. Hezekiah's god won't deliver his people* either*."*

[18]They shouted it out in the language of Judah to the people on the wall to terrify them so they could take the city. [19]They talked about the God of Jerusalem like the other people's hand-made gods.

[20]But King Hezekiah and the prophet Isaiah Ben-Amoz, prayed about that and appealed to Heaven. [21]Yahveh sent an angel that destroyed every powerful soldier, commander, and officer in the camp. *Sennacherib* went back to his own land humiliated. When he entered the temple of his god, *two* of his own sons killed him with a sword. [22]Yahveh saved Hezekiah, the people in Jerusalem, and the rest and guided them on every side. [23]Many people started bringing gifts to Yahveh at Jerusalem and special presents to Hezekiah so that all the nations regarded him highly after that. **2 Ch 32:16-23**

Hezekiah's Sickness and Recovery

[24]At that time, Hezekiah became deathly ill. He prayed to Yahveh, and he answered him and gave him a sign. [25-26]Hezekiah and the people in Jerusalem humbled themselves, so Yahveh's wrath didn't come on them during his lifetime.

[27]Hezekiah had immense wealth and honor. He made treasuries for silver, gold, precious stones, spices, shields, and all kinds of valuable articles; [28]as well as storehouses for grain, wine, and olive oil; pens for all kinds of livestock, and shepherds for the flocks. [29]He built towns for himself and acquired flocks and herds in abundance. [30]Hezekiah was the one that stopped the upper outlet of Gihon and diverted the water to the west side of The City of David. He succeeded at everything. [31]Even in regard to envoys from Babylon who asked about the wonder that had happened, God left him alone to test him, to know what was in his heart.

Summary of Hezekiah's Reign

[32]The rest of his acts and his deeds of devotion are recorded in *The Vision of the Prophet Isaiah Ben-Amoz* and *The Book of the Kings of Judah and Israel*. [33]He died and they buried him in the upper section of the tombs of David's descendants. The people in Judah and Jerusalem honored him when he died. His son Manasseh became king. **2 Ch 32:24-33**

Manasseh Rules Judah

33:[1]**Manasseh** was 12 and ruled for 55 years in Jerusalem. [2]He did evil like the nations Yahveh drove out. [3]He rebuilt the high places Hezekiah had torn down, erected altars for the images of Baal, set up Asherah poles, and worshiped and served the stars in the sky. [4]He built altars in Yahveh's Temple where Yahveh had said, *"I will identify with Jerusalem permanently."* [5]He built altars for the host of heaven in the two courts of Yahveh's Temple. [6]He burned his sons as an offering in the Valley of (Ben)Hinnom. He angered Yahveh with lots of sins he did: witchcraft, fortunetelling, sorcery, consulting mediums and spiritists. [7]Then he put in God's Temple the carved image of the idol he'd made about which God had told David and Solomon his son,

> *"I've chosen to identify myself permanently with this Temple and with Jerusalem out of all the tribes in Israel.* [8]*I won't again remove Israel from the land I've appointed for their ancestors, if only they'll observe everything I've commanded them in the Law, statutes, and ordinances I gave through Moses."*

[9]Manasseh misled Judah and Jerusalem to sin more than the nations Yahveh originally destroyed in front of the Israelites. **2 Ch 33:1-9**

[10]Yahveh spoke to Manasseh and his people, but they didn't pay any attention. [11]So he brought the commanders of Assyria's army against them. They captured Manasseh with hooks, bound him with bronze chains, and took him to Babylon. [12]When he was in distress, he appealed to Yahveh and humbled himself greatly in the presence of his ancestors' God. [13]When he prayed to him, God was moved by his appeal, and brought him back to Jerusalem to his kingdom. Then Manasseh knew Yahveh was God.

[14]After that, he built an outer wall for The City of David on the west side of the Gihon in the valley, as far as the entrance to the Fish Gate. It encircled Ophel and it was very tall. Then he put army commanders in the fortified towns of Judah. [15]He removed the foreign gods and the idol from Yahveh's Temple as well as the altars he'd built *earlier* on the mountain of Yahveh and in Jerusalem, and dumped them outside the city. [16]He set up Yahveh's altar and sacrificed peace offerings and thank offerings on it. He ordered Judah to serve Yahveh God of Israel. [17]The people still sacrificed in the high places, but only to Yahveh. **2 Ch 33:10-17**

[18]The rest of the acts of Manasseh, including his prayer to God and the words of the seers that spoke to him in Yahveh's name, are in *The Chronicles of the Kings of Israel*. [19]Also recorded in *The Chronicles of the Seers* are his sin and unfaithfulness, the sites where he built high places, set up Asherah poles and carved images before he humbled himself and appealed to God. [20]Manasseh died, and they buried him in his own house. His son Amon became king.

Amon Rules Judah

[21]**Amon** was 22 and ruled for 2 years in Jerusalem. [22]He did evil like Manasseh had done. He sacrificed to the carved images his father had made and served them. [23]He didn't humble himself like his father did, but multiplied his guilt. [24]Finally, his own officials murdered him in his own house, [25]but the people killed them and made his son Josiah king. **2 Ch 33:18-25**

Josiah Rules Judah

34:1Josiah was 8 and ruled for 31 years in Jerusalem. [2]He did what was good and didn't stray from the ways of David. [3]In **his eighth year**, while he was still young, he began to look to David's God. In **his twelfth year** he began to purge Judah and Jerusalem of the high places, Asherah poles, and carved and molten images. [4]The *people* tore down the Baal altars and chopped down the incense altars above them. The Asherah poles, carved images, and molten images he broke in pieces, ground into powder, and scattered on the graves of those who had sacrificed to them. [5]He burned the bones of the priests on their altars. [6]In the towns and surrounding ruins in Manasseh, Ephraim, and Simeon as far as Naphtali, [7]he destroyed the altars and Asherah poles, beat the carved images into powder, and chopped down the incense altars everywhere in Israel. **2 Ch 34:1-7**

[8]In **his eighteenth year**, he sent Shaphan Ben-Azaliah; Maaseiah, an official of the city; and Joah Ben-Joahaz, the recorder, to repair the Temple. [9]They delivered to Hilkiah the high priest the money that came into God's Temple that the Levites, the doorkeepers, had collected from Manasseh, Ephraim, the remnant of Israel, Judah and Benjamin, and the people in Jerusalem. [10]They gave it to the workmen that oversaw the Temple. [11]They in turn gave it to the carpenters and builders to buy quarried stone and timber for couplings and to make beams for the

houses the kings of Judah had let fall into ruin. [12]The men did the work faithfully under their foremen: Jahath and Obadiah, Levites descended from Merari; Zechariah and Meshullam from the Kohathites, and the Levites skillful with musical instruments. [13]They also supervised the carriers and workmen from job to job. Some Levites were secretaries, officials, and gatekeepers.

2 Ch 34:8-13

The Book of the Law Discovered

[14]When they were bringing out the money that had come in, Hilkiah the priest found the Book of the Law that Moses gave. [15]He told Shaphan the secretary, *"I've found the Book of the Law in the Temple."* He gave it to him [16]to take to the king,

> *"Your officials are doing everything you entrusted to them.* [17]*They've emptied out the money they found in the*[Y] *Temple, and delivered it to the foremen and workmen.* [18]*Hilkiah gave me a scroll."*

He read it to the king. [19]When the king heard what the Law said, he tore his clothes. [20]He told Hilkiah, Ahikam Ben-Shaphan, Abdon Ben-Micah, Shaphan the secretary, and Asaiah the king's aide,

> [21]*"Go ask Yahveh and the ones left in Israel and Judah about what the scroll says. Yahveh poured out his great anger on us because our ancestors haven't observed what's written here."*

2 Ch 34:14-21

[22]Hilkiah and the others spoke to Huldah the prophetess, wife of Shallum Ben-Tokhath Ben-Hasrah, the keeper of the wardrobe. (She lived in Jerusalem's Second Quarter.) [23]She said,

> *"Yahveh God of Israel says to tell the man that sent you,* [24]*'I'm bringing disaster on this place and its people, the curses written in the scroll they've read to the king.* [25]*They've left me and burned incense to other gods to offend me. My anger won't be quenched.'*
>
> [26]*"But tell the king Yahveh says,* [27]*'I've heard you because your heart was sensitive. You humbled yourself when you heard what I said against this place and its people. You tore your clothes and cried.* [28]*I'll gather you to your ancestors in peace so you won't see the disaster I'm going to bring on this place and its people.'"*

They brought the message back to the king.

2 Ch 34:22-28

Josiah's Reforms

[29]Then the king gathered the elders in Judah [30]and went up to Yahveh's Temple with the people of Judah and Jerusalem, the priests, the Levites, and the people from least to greatest. He read to them everything in the Book of the Covenant that *Hilkiah* found. [31]He stood in his place to renew the covenant to follow Yahveh and keep his commandments, testimonies, and statutes with all his heart and soul—like the covenant said in that scroll. [32]He made everybody present in Jerusalem and Benjamin stand with him. The people in Jerusalem obeyed the covenant with their

ancestors' God. [33]Josiah removed the detestable things from the territory that belonged to the Israelites and made everybody in Israel serve Yahveh their God. They followed him his whole life. **2 Ch 34:29-33**

Josiah Celebrates the Passover

35:[1]Then Josiah celebrated Passover to Yahveh in Jerusalem. They killed the Passover *animals* on the fourteenth of the first month. [2]He appointed the priests to their offices and encouraged them in the service for the Temple. [3]He told the Levites that taught Israel and were holy to Yahveh,

> *"Put the holy Ark in the Temple Solomon built. It won't be a burden on your shoulder anymore. Serve Yahveh your God and his people Israel.* [4]*Prepare yourselves by divisions within families like David and Solomon wrote.* [5]*Stand in the Holy Place by those divisions of your relatives the lay people. With the Levites make divisions within families.* [6]*Slaughter the Passover* animals*, sanctify yourselves, and be ready to do for your relatives what Yahveh said by Moses."*
>
> **2 Ch 35:1-6**

[7]For Passover offerings, Josiah contributed out of his own stock 30,000 lambs and kids for the lay people that were present plus 3,000 bulls. [8]His officers also contributed a freewill offering to the people, priests, and Levites. For the Passover, Hilkiah, Zechariah, and Jehiel, the officials of God's Temple, gave the priests 2,600 *from flocks* and 300 bulls. [9]For the Passover, Conaniah—and his brothers Shemaiah and Nethanel—and Hashabiah, Jeiel, and Jozabad, officers of the Levites, contributed to the Levites 5,000 *from the flocks* and 500 bulls.

[10]So the service was ready, and the priests and Levites stood at their stations by their divisions. [11]They killed the Passover *animals*. While the priests sprinkled the blood, the Levites skinned them. [12]Then they removed the burnt offerings so they could give them to the divisions of families in the lay people to present to Yahveh the way the Book of Moses says. They did the same thing with the bulls. [13]They roasted the Passover *animals* on the fire as required by the Law, boiled the holy things in pots, kettles, and pans; and carried them quickly away to the people. [14]Afterward they prepared for themselves and the priests, because the priests, the descendants of Aaron, were offering the burnt offerings and fat till dark. So the Levites prepared for themselves and the priests. [15]The singers, descendants of Asaph, were also at their stations like David commanded: Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun the king's seer. The gatekeepers didn't have to step aside from serving at each gate, because their relatives, the Levites, prepared for them. **2 Ch 35:7-15**

[16]So the service of Yahveh was ready that day to celebrate Passover and to offer burnt offerings on Yahveh's altar like King Josiah commanded. [17]The Israelites that were present celebrated Passover and the Festival of Unleavened Bread for a week. [18]Israelites hadn't celebrated Passover like that since Samuel the prophet. No king in Israel celebrated such a

Passover as Josiah did with the priests, Levites, Judah, and Israel present with the people in Jerusalem. [19]They celebrated it in the **eighteenth year** of Josiah's reign. **2 Ch 35:16-19**

Josiah Dies in Battle

[20]After Josiah had set the Temple in order, Neco, king of Egypt, went up to fight at Carchemish on the Euphrates, and Josiah went out to engage him. [21]But Neco sent ambassadors to him,

> *"What do we have to do with each other, King of Judah? I'm not coming against you; I'm fighting another nation, and God has ordered me to hurry. For your own sake, stop interfering with God, who is with me, so he doesn't destroy you."* **2 Ch 35:20-21**

[22]But Josiah wouldn't turn away; he disguised himself. He ignored what God said from Neco and went ahead to fight him on the plain of Megiddo. [23]The archers shot him, and he told his officers, *"Take me away; I'm badly wounded."* [24]They took him out of the chariot, put him in a second one he had, and took him to Jerusalem, where he died. They buried him in the tombs of his ancestors. Judah and Jerusalem mourned for him. [25]Jeremiah chanted a lament for him. The male and female singers still speak about him in *The Lamentations*. They made them an ordinance in Israel; they're written in *The Lamentations*. [26]The rest of the deeds and devotions of Josiah are written in *The Law of Yahveh*. [27]His acts, first to last, are recorded in *The Book of the Kings of Israel and Judah*. **2 Ch 35:22-27**

Jehoahaz Rules Judah

36:[1]The people took **Joahaz** Ben-Josiah and made him king. [2]He was 23 and ruled for 3 months in Jerusalem. [3]The king of Egypt deposed him and imposed on the land a fine of 7550 lbs [100 talents] of silver and 75.5 lbs [a talent] of gold. [4]The king of Egypt made Eliakim his brother king over Judah and Jerusalem and changed his name to **Jehoiakim**. But Neco took Joahaz to Egypt. [5]Jehoiakim was 25. He ruled for 11 years in Jerusalem and did evil. [6]Nebuchadnezzar came up against him, bound him with bronze *chains*, and took him to Babylon. [7]He took some articles from the[Y] Temple to Babylon and put them in his temple. [8]The rest of the acts of Jehoiakim, his disgusting deeds, and the charges against him are recorded in *The Book of the Kings of Israel and Judah*. His son Jehoiachin became king. **2 Ch 36:1-8**

Jehoiachin Rules Judah

[9]**Jehoiachin** was 8 and ruled for 3 months and 10 days in Jerusalem. He did evil. [10]At the beginning of the new year, King Nebuchadnezzar sent and took him to Babylon with the valuable articles from the[Y] Temple. He made his relative Zedekiah king of Judah and Jerusalem.

Zedekiah Rules Judah

[11]**Zedekiah** was 21 and ruled for 11 years in Jerusalem. [12]He did evil and didn't humble himself toward Jeremiah Yahveh's prophet. [13]He also revolted against Nebuchadnezzar, who had made him swear by God. He stiffened his neck and hardened his heart against turning to Yahveh God of Israel. [14]In addition, the officials of the priests and the people were unfaithful and followed the detestable things of the nations. They defiled Yahveh's Temple that he'd sanctified in Jerusalem.

[15]Yahveh God of their ancestors sent word to them repeatedly by his messengers, because he had mercy on them and the place where he lived. [16]But they despised his messages and scoffed at his prophets till his wrath rose up against them without remedy. **2 Ch 36:9-16**

The Fall of Jerusalem

[17]So he brought up the king of the Babylonians against them. He killed their young men with the sword in their sanctuary. He didn't show mercy to young man or virgin, old man or infirm. Yahveh delivered them all to him. [18]He took to Babylon the articles from the Temple, large and small, the treasures in the Temple, and the treasures the king and his officers had. [19]They burned God's Temple, tore down the wall around Jerusalem, burned its fortified buildings, and destroyed its valuable articles. [20]The ones that escaped the sword he took as servants to himself and his sons till the kingdom of Persia. [21]*That* fulfilled Jeremiah's message that the land would keep sabbath for 70 years, the days of its desolation. **2 Ch 36:17-21**

Cyrus Lets the Exiles Return

[22]In the first year of Cyrus, king of Persia, in fulfillment of Yahveh's message through Jeremiah, Yahveh stirred up Cyrus. He sent a written proclamation everywhere in his kingdom:

> [23]***"Cyrus, king of Persia, says, 'Yahveh God of heaven has given me the kingdoms of the world, and has appointed me to build him a temple in Jerusalem, in Judah. Whoever there is among you from his people, Yahveh your God be with you! Go up!'"*** **2 Ch 36:22-23**

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